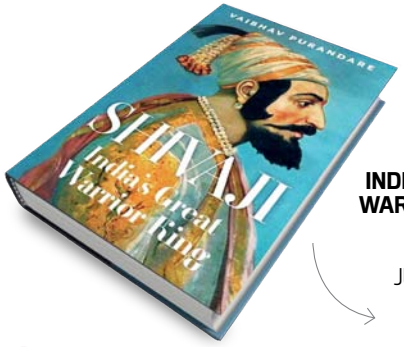


SHIVAJI: INDIA'S GREAT WARRIOR KING
By Vaibhav Purandare
JUGGERNAUT
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BOOKS

THE KING OF HEARTS

*Though Vaibhav Purandare holds **Shivaji** in high esteem, his book on the Maratha king is no hagiography*

Finally, a new biography of Shivaji in English in which legend does not overshadow recorded history. Vaibhav Purandare is an obvious admirer, but is careful in situating his subject in his 17th century context.

The broad details of Shivaji's epic story are well known, but Purandare has ably mined the vast literature that has grown around the Maratha king from the late 19th century; his text is further illuminated by contemporary European accounts and primary sources in Marathi. The net result is an accessible English biography, especially good for the reader who seeks a change from the pathbreaking but century-old work on Shivaji by Jadunath Sarkar.

Shivaji's influence over a large part of the 17th century acquired a larger-than-life role in our national consciousness from the end of the 19th century. History and hagiography thereafter often got mixed. In this work, the author remains conscious of the weight of both elements without letting them overwhelm his account.

The popular narrative around Shivaji is largely framed by his long contest with Aurangzeb. But his geopolitical environment in the first three quarters of the 17th century was more complex. His more immediate rivalry was with the Sultanate of Bijapur in whose armies his father had served. It was against Bijapur that Shivaji had to first act in order to consolidate his putative dominion. The Mughal expansion southwards was a threat, but it also provided an opportunity given the adversarial relations with Bijapur. Alongside were other factors, including outposts of European power in the form of trading companies along the western coast, and intra-Maratha feuding.

Purandare has ensured that legend doesn't overshadow recorded history

Shivaji's great quality, and something that enthralls all his biographers, was the single-minded pursuit of his and his people's interests through this maze of conflicting forces. His most celebrated feats—the killing of the Bijapur general Afzal Khan, the night raid on the Mughal Viceroy Shaista Khan, the escape from Aurangzeb's custody in Agra—were a demonstration of his personal courage and tactical brilliance. Besides this, he also showed a greater consciousness of the maritime domain than any of his predecessors or contemporary powers in medieval India, and that in itself shows his distinctive quality.

Shivaji's major adversaries were Muslims. His refusal to accept a subordinate status under Bijapur or the Mughals inevitably adds a religious dimension to his story. But did he seek through his resistance to found a theocratic Hindu state to counter the turn to orthodoxy and bigotry that both Bijapur and the Mughals progressively demonstrated through his life span? Varied answers have been provided by different historians. In Purandare's reading, Shivaji consciously adopted Hindu motifs and symbolism to energise his followers, and this distinctively marked his realm. But alongside, perhaps the kingdom he founded shared other attributes with these contemporary states than Purandare acknowledges.

More significantly, as Purandare emphasises, he was not a ruler guided by religious and sectarian considerations; he "fashioned his own template of governance" and this was of a "robust expression—by way of words and actions- to values of religious plurality". In the mid to late 17th century, if this appears incredibly modern, it is all the more reason to celebrate the great Maratha. ■

-T.C.A. Raghavan

(The writer is a retired diplomat and the author of **History Men: Jadunath Sarkar, G.S. Sardesai, Raghubir Sinh and Their Quest for India's Past***)*